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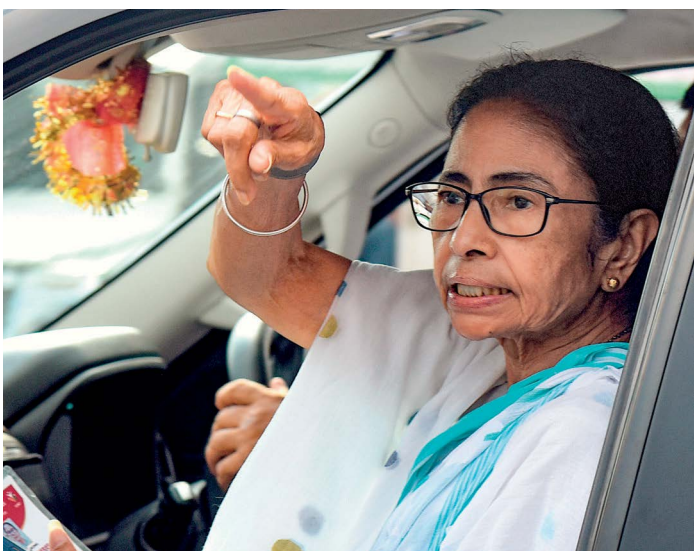
MANDATE 2026

| WEST BENGAL |

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AS THE PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI-LED BJP VANQUISHES MAMATA TO TAKE BENGAL, THE INSIDE STORY OF THE RELENTLESS DETERMINATION, DELIBERATE STRATEGY AND FLAWLESS EXECUTION THAT LED TO THE SAFFRON SWEEP

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ANI

TO celebrate the BJP's historic conquest of West Bengal, Prime Minister Narendra Modi arrived at the party headquarters in Delhi on May 4 dressed in traditional Bengali attire—a *dhuti-panjabi*. Addressing the ecstatic party workers assembled before him, PM Modi spoke to them with the satisfaction of a leader who had waited nearly a decade for this moment. "From Gangotri to Gangasagar," he proclaimed, "the lotus has bloomed everywhere." Then, pausing over each state as though marking milestones in a long political journey, he traced the BJP's sweep across the Ganga's riverine course: Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and now, finally, West Bengal. The entire Gangetic heartland, he declared, was now in the BJP-NDA fold.

Just a fortnight ago, a seamless coup had been executed in Bihar, which saw Samrat Chaudhary becoming the BJP's first-ever chief minister of the state after incumbent Nitish Kumar resigned following an elevation to the Rajya Sabha. Two years earlier, the party had ousted five-time chief minister Naveen Patnaik in Odisha and installed the first BJP chief minister in the state. But its biggest breakthrough has been Bengal this summer, where the BJP stunned everyone by winning 207 out of the 294 seats in the assembly, securing a vote share of 45.9 per cent and breaching the formidable citadel chief minister Mamata Banerjee and her party, the Trinamool Congress (TMC), had built over three consecutive terms. The TMC was reduced to 80 seats despite a 40.8 per cent vote share, with the remaining six seats going to other Opposition parties.

The win in Bengal has helped the BJP complete what Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan called the Anga-Banga-Kalinga, or Bihar, Bengal and Odisha, rendered in the old Pauranic vocabulary. In Assam, the BJP, along with its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners, struck a creditable hat-trick, winning 102 out of the state's 126 seats. It also found small consolation in the South, where the NDA retained power in Puducherry.

Bengal, though, is undoubtedly the biggest prize. For the BJP and its ideological fountainhead, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), Bengal is the homeland of Syama Prasad Mookerjee, founder of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh, progenitor of the BJP. For seven decades, the organisation he built contested every election in the state, with little success, but with the patience of a movement that treats history in longer arcs than electoral cycles. That Bengal

Photograph by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR